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What is hard and what is easy

When we think of a given government intervention, we need to judge how hard it would be for successful implementation. Suppose the Indian state is evaluating a universal human papillomavirus (HPV) immunization programme for children. While we know that this is hard, it is in the zone of feasible policy pathways. But suppose the Indian state is evaluating a programme where officials will interview unemployed individuals and decide which of them should get welfare payments every month. This seems beyond the reach of the implementation capacity of the Indian state.

What are the general principles through which we can engage in such reasoning?

Four dimensions of complexity

Lant Pritchett and Michael Woolcock first posed this question and offered elements of the answer. [1] They predict that implementation is hard when there is more discretion and when there are a larger number of transactions. In addition, implementation is harder when there is more at stake for private persons, and when there is more secrecy.

Number of transactions: It is easier to achieve state capacity on a problem where there are a smaller number of transactions. A vast sprawling machinery involves greater agency problems; it is difficult to be sure that every element of the administrative machine is working correctly.